Math That Doesn't Work

A word before the rest of the plan

Ben,

This one goes in front of the Homecoming Plan, because it names the thing the rest of that plan is built to protect — and it is the one piece nobody thought to tell either of us until now.

Read it once through. **Then read the last page again with a pen.**

— *Grampy*

Somewhere on the flight home, most missionaries do a quiet piece of unconscious math. It goes like this.

Before the mission, my life was work, school, and the people I loved. Family, friends, church, maybe dating. Then I traded all of that for two years of one thing.

Now I hand back the badge. **I keep who I became** — I am not the same person who got on that plane, and nobody can take that from me. **I let go of the skills**, because nobody knocks doors in Provo and the first lesson has no use at a job interview. Then I pick the old life back up.

Keep the growth. Drop what no longer applies. Add back the rest. Balanced.

That is a careful ledger. Every line of it is defensible. And it is still wrong — not wrong by a little. Wrong about what kind of problem it is.

First, answer one question honestly

Were you more content in your last year before the mission, or in your last year on it?

Take your time. Nearly every missionary answers the same way.

Now look at what that answer means. **Before the mission you had *more* going on** — school, work, friends, family, a whole ordinary life. On the mission you had **less.** Two years of doing one thing, in a small apartment, with one companion.

More things, less joy. Fewer things, more joy.

So whatever made those two years feel the way they felt, **it was not the number of things in your life.** You already know this. You have simply never been handed the words for it.

What actually changed

Here is the same math, written a second way. It is only two ideas, and the second one is the whole point.

Some things in a life are **items.** You can count them. Work is an item. School is an item. Your friends, your family, your calling — items. You add them up.

But one thing in a life is not an item. **It is what all the items are *for*.** It is a multiplier. Call it your purpose, your reason for being, your center — the one thing that made getting out of bed at 6:30 a decision you had made early on, and easy to maintain.

Written out:

> **Before: Life = (work + school + people) × 1**
>
> **Mission: Life = (one purpose) × a very large number**
>
> **Home: Life = who you became + (work + school + people) × 1**

Read the middle line again. **The mission's sum was tiny. Its multiplier was enormous.** That is why a narrowly focused life felt so large.

Now read the third line, and notice where *who you became* sits. **It is an ITEM added on. It is not doing any multiplying.** That is the part you are least likely to be warned about, because most of the warning you get is running **Human Math.**

And that brings me to the thing I most want you to carry out of this — the reason it is written down instead of spoken, so that you can come back to it.

There are two kinds of math running in a man's life, and very few realize that there is a second one, let alone name it.

> **Human Math adds. Divine Math multiplies.**

So let me tell you exactly what Divine Math is, because you have probably never been given a name for it.

Divine Math is the internal, always-running, subconscious calculator that is trying to keep your life in balance from a celestial perspective. It never shuts off. It has been running the entire time you have been out. **Human Math does not even know it exists, so it cannot begin to acknowledge it** — and it is a power that moves a man onto an ever higher and more exalted plane of performance.

Now read that again slowly, because there is something in it for you today.

If that calculator is always running, then it is running right now. And it is reporting a number.

That unease you have been feeling about coming home is not weakness and it is not ingratitude. It is the readout. Divine Math has already run the arithmetic on the life you are about to walk into, and it is telling you the answer. **You simply have had no display to read it on and no words to say it in.** That is what this is for.

Human Math counts what is in your life. It is honest, it is careful, and it is what every good person around you will use to reassure you that things are filling back up. **Divine Math asks a different question altogether: not how much is in your life, but what is multiplying it.**

You have been living inside Divine Math for two years, and it has most likely gone unnamed. From here on I am going to call it exactly that — and I want you to know it well enough that you cannot unsee it.

Put real numbers on it

Pick a number for what one part of your life is worth. Say each part is worth **3.** The number itself does not matter. **Only what happens to it matters.**

Before the mission — three parts, nothing multiplying them:

> $3 + 3 + 3 = 9 \rightarrow \times \mathbf{1} \rightarrow \mathbf{9}$

On the mission — one part, one purpose, and a multiplier that was real. Call it 10:

> $3 \rightarrow \times \mathbf{10} \rightarrow \mathbf{30}$

Stop on that. **You went from three things to one thing, and the total went from 9 to 30.** Your life got smaller and three times bigger *at the same time*. That is not a feeling you had. **That is arithmetic.**

Coming home — three parts again, plus what you became. Call that 2:

> 3 + 3 + 3 = 9 → **× 1** → **9** → **+ 2** → **11**

Nine, then thirty, then eleven.

Everyone around you is counting the *parts* — three, then one, then three — and telling you that you are back to normal. But **YOU** are not looking at the parts. **You are looking at 30 and 11.**

Counting the parts is Human Math. The distance between 11 and 30 is Divine Math.

Now try to add your way back

Here is the piece worth doing on your fingers.

You are sitting at 11 and you remember 30. So you do what everybody does. **You add.** Another class. A better job. A calling. A relationship. A side business. The gym.

Stop right there and notice which calculator you just picked up. Adding is Human Math. It is very likely the only tool anyone has handed you, so of course you reached for it. **Now watch exactly what it can and cannot do.**

> Add a fourth part: 3 + 3 + 3 + 3 = 12, + 2 = **14**
>
> A fifth: **17**
>
> A sixth: **20**

Keep going and see where it ends. **To reach 30 by adding alone, you need nine parts** — nine real commitments, each one as heavy as school or work, all running at once, forever.

Nobody has room for nine. You would come apart somewhere around five. **And you would come apart at 17.**

That is Human Math giving you everything it has — nine commitments, to reach a number you were holding two years ago with one.

Now put that calculator down and pick up the other one:

> One part. Multiplier back to 10. **3 × 10 = 30**

That is Divine Math, and it took one line.

One thing multiplied beat nine things added. That is why a returned missionary who is genuinely busy — classes, job, ward, gym, dating, side hustle — can still feel like he is losing ground. **He is not lazy. He is adding.** He is running Human Math flawlessly — and

Human Math has never gotten anybody to 30.

And here is what most of that room will not know

When you walk into your homecoming, **most of the people there will be doing Human Math on you.** They will not know they are doing it. **For most of them it is the only math they have ever been handed.**

Here is what Human Math sees when it looks at your two years:

> **He served a mission.** One more good thing, on a list of good things. A line on the record of a righteous life. **An item. Added.**

And they will be genuinely, honestly happy about it. They will hug you and mean every word. **They are not wrong about a single thing they say.** They are simply *counting.*

Here is what actually happened to you, and few in that room are likely to have been taught it.

You did not add a mission to your life. You made a connection to God that multiplied it — and then you lived inside that multiplication, hour after hour, for two years, until it felt like ordinary weather.

That is why so few warn you. A man cannot warn you about losing something he does not know you had.

They are celebrating an addition. You are about to lose a multiplier. Both of those things will be true in the same room on the same afternoon, and only one person there will be able to feel it.

And you will not be able to explain it to them — not because they are shallow, but because Human Math has no word for the thing that is leaving.

Now you have one.

Why 1 is the sneakiest number in arithmetic

There are exactly two operations that leave no evidence behind.

Add zero — nothing changes. **Multiply by one** — nothing changes.

That is your whole situation in one line. **Your multiplier did not go to zero.** If it had, you would have known within a week — a life at zero is a crisis, and crises get help. **It went to one.**

And **× 1 looks completely fine.** Your life still adds up. You are still busy, still faithful, still going to church, still moving. Nothing is missing from the list — **because a multiplier was never on the list.**

A man at × 1 is not in trouble. He is just never going to see 30 again.

Human Math has no column for a multiplier, so it will score that life as a good one. Divine Math knows better — and so, quietly, does he.

So what is the multiplier, actually?

Fair question, and you should not accept a vague answer. **If I cannot tell you what the number actually is, I have handed you a nice picture and nothing you can use on a Tuesday.**

So here it is. **Your multiplier is your honest answer to one question, asked of any hour of your day:**

Who is this for?

That is the whole thing. **Not how hard you worked. Not how spiritual it felt. Who it was for.**

On your mission you never once had to ask. The answer was printed on your chest, and everybody could read it — including you. Every hour, every door, every meal, every study session had a name on it that was not yours. **Two years without ever having to wonder who the day belonged to.**

Then you took the badge off, and the question came back — and it is unlikely anyone told you it had.

	Who is this hour for?	What it does
× 1	**Me.** My grade, my paycheck, my comfort, my future	counts for exactly what it is
× 3	**Someone who already loves me** — family, a friend, someone who will thank me	counts for more
× 10	**God, and whoever He put in front of me today** — whether it works, whether anyone sees, whether anyone thanks me	**multiplies**

Read that ladder carefully, because none of those rows is a sin. × 1 is not wickedness. **It is a rate.** Eating breakfast is × 1 and you still have to eat. Paying rent is × 1. **The problem is never one × 1 hour. It is a whole life lived on the top row and none of it on the bottom.**

And here is the part that will surprise you

The activity does not have to change at all.

Take one hour. Studying chemistry.

- Studying so you get the grade you need — **× 1.**
- Studying because you intend to become a man who can carry weight for other people, and this is where that gets built — **more.**
- Studying beside the kid who is failing, and slowing yourself down to help him — **more again.**

Now look at your calendar in all three cases. It is identical. Same hour, same book, same room, same tired eyes. **That is exactly why Human Math cannot see any of this — and why nobody around you will ever be able to tell you what your number is.**

Only you know who the hour was for. Which means only you can set your multiplier, and only you can let it slide back to 1.

The scripture that shows the work

King Benjamin handed you this equation long before you were born:

> *"When ye are in the service of your fellow beings ye are only in the service of your God."* (Mosiah 2:17)

Read it as arithmetic and not as poetry. The act does not change. **Who it counts for does.** An ordinary hour, given to a person, is credited to God. **That is the multiplication — and it is the one place I know of where the Lord shows His work.**

Which tells you what a purpose actually is

Now you can see what that placeholder I am going to ask you for really is.

It is a **standing answer** to *who is this for* — decided once, in advance, on a good day, **so that you are not renegotiating it at 6:30 on a cold morning when you are tired and nobody is watching.**

That is all a purpose has ever been: the answer you already gave.

You did not lose the skills. You lost the multiplier

The skills are the loss you can see. You will not knock doors again. You will not teach the first lesson again. **That loss is real and it is small** — those were never what made the two years feel the way they did.

The multiplier is what actually came off with the badge. You handed it back at the pulpit on the day you reported, and nobody mentioned it, because it does not appear anywhere on the list of things you turned in.

And keeping who you became will not save you

This is the line in your ledger you trust most, and you are right to trust it. **You did grow. That growth is real and it is permanent and it is yours.**

But look at what kind of thing it is. **Who you became is a height. The multiplier is a climb rate.**

You can stand higher than you did at eighteen and be **completely stopped** — and the two feel identical from the inside, because you are, in fact, higher up than you were. **The growth is exactly what will convince you that nothing is wrong.** It is also what will convince your parents, your bishop, and every person who tells you how much the mission changed you.

They are all right. And none of it is the multiplier.

So look hard at that third line. **You did not come home to balance. You came home to where you started — standing a little higher, and moving at the same speed you were at eighteen. That is exactly the problem.** At eighteen you did not know there was another speed. Now you do.

You are not falling. You are being set back down at a rate you already found thin — and everyone around you is calling it getting back to normal.

Why the obvious answers will not fix it

You are about to be told, kindly and constantly, to go get four things: **a career. An education. A marriage and a family. A calling in the ward.**

Get all four. Every one of them is good, and you should want them.

That list is Human Math's answer, and it is a fine answer. It is simply the wrong operation.

But not one of them can be your multiplier. Here is why, and it is not about how worthy they are.

They are items. They live inside the sum. **A thing that is being added cannot also be the thing doing the multiplying.**

Three things follow, and each one is worth knowing before it happens to you.

Ask an item to be your multiplier and it will break. A wife asked to be the meaning of a man's life has been handed a job no person can do, and the marriage bends under a weight that was never hers to carry. The same is true of a job, a degree, and one day your children.

Items come and go on somebody else's schedule. A calling is given, and later released. A job is offered, and later lost. A spouse you have not met yet cannot hold anything for you today. **Anything held for you by someone else is scaffolding** — and you already know from the Scaffolding Audit what happens to a man whose walls were all held up from outside.

And church service is the one that fools good people. It is an item too. It is assigned to you, timed by someone else, and released when someone else decides. **A man can be genuinely busy in the kingdom and be running an unmultiplied life** — and he will be thanked for it the whole way, because from the outside, service and purpose look exactly alike.

Why it has to be every day

One more thing from grade school, and it matters more than it sounds.

In any math problem, you multiply before you add. You learned that as a rule about which part to do first. It is also true about your day.

Whatever your multiplier is set to when you wake up gets applied to everything that comes after — the class you didn't want, the shift you didn't want, the conversation you weren't ready for. You do not get to add your day up first and then decide afterward how much it counted. **The multiplying already happened.**

That is why this is a morning practice and not an evening one. You set the number *before* you find out what the day holds.

Divine Math always multiplies first. Human Math waits until bedtime to add the day up, and then wonders why the total came out so thin.

And the number does not hold itself. Your multiplier is not a tank you fill once. **It is more like a fire.** It goes out on its own unless something is put on it today.

You already have this in your bones from the mission. Part 4 of the Homecoming Plan says it plainly: your spirit loses strength **in direct proportion to how long it has been since it was last fed.** That is not a poem. That is a rate. **It leaks on a schedule, whether or not you are paying attention.**

Which means:

A purpose you tend once a week is a purpose leaking six days out of seven.

And here is the cruel part — **nothing feels wrong while it is happening.** You do not fall off the mountain. **You just stop gaining altitude.** The climb flattens out, slowly, over months. And a man who has stopped climbing looks exactly like a man who is resting — including to himself.

That is Wall 1. *Keep climbing.* It is the first wall on the list because it is the first to go, and because when it goes, it takes the other eleven with it — quietly, one at a time. **The test is the one you already know: have you named your next pitch?**

So: choose a placeholder, today

You are twenty-one. **You are not going to know your life's mission by Thursday**, and anyone who tells you that you should is adding a weight you do not need.

But you cannot afford to run at ×1 while you wait.

A placeholder is simply how you set the multiplier while you wait — and it is the one move in Divine Math that nobody else can make for you.

So choose a **placeholder** — an honest, temporary center, held on purpose until the real one becomes clear. It is allowed to be temporary. **That is not a failure of faith. That is how it works, and it is how it worked for the man who wrote this.**

A good placeholder passes six tests:

	It must be	Because
1	**Not one of the four**	an item can't multiply the sum it's in

	It must be	Because
2	**Yours — chosen, not assigned**	nobody can release you from it
3	**Doable today, even on a bad day**	it leaks daily, so it's fed daily
4	**Bigger than you, and never finished**	anything you can complete has an end date
5	**Portable**	new city, new campus, hard semester
6	**Allowed to change**	when the real one arrives, that's arrival — not failure

---

Ten that pass

Do not read these politely and move on. They are here because "choose a placeholder" is useless advice without something to choose from. **Every one of these clears all six tests. None of them is a career, a degree, a marriage, or a calling.**

	The placeholder	What it actually means
1	**Learn the doctrine well enough to teach it to someone who does not want it**	Not study for a class. Study for the person who will ask you the hard question five years from now, in a kitchen, with no manual in reach
2	**Carry one person nobody is assigned to**	One name, chosen by you, in your prayers and on your calendar — and never because a bishop asked
3	**Hand it to the one who is where you were**	A deacon, a future missionary, a new convert. You give the two years away on purpose (Luke 22:32)
4	**Be the one in every room who tells the truth kindly**	Not the loudest. Not the most correct. The one who can be trusted with a hard sentence
5	**Become the man your family will need before there is a family**	The trap is letting this quietly turn into *get married.* The work is **you**, and it is due whether or not anybody shows up
6	**Keep the record of your own becoming**	Your feast log, extended into a life. Written daily, read back yearly. You will not remember this year otherwise
7	**Become your family's memory**	Gather the stories and the names while the people who hold them are still here to tell you
8	**Master one hard thing that will never make you money**	An instrument, a language, a distance, a craft. Proof that you can still pay a price for something with no payout
9	**Get strong enough that your body is never the reason you cannot**	The appetites the mission held at bay come back first. This is Wall 10 turned into a purpose instead of a rule

	The placeholder	What it actually means
10	**Understand the ones who left**	Learn honestly *why* people leave — so that when it is someone you love, you can love them accurately instead of arguing with them

Two ways to get this wrong

The first trap: choosing one of the four in disguise. *"My purpose is to provide for my family."* That is a career wearing a coat. *"My purpose is to serve in the Church."* That is a calling wearing a coat. **Test it: could someone else give it to you, or take it away? Then it is an item.**

The second trap: choosing something too large to pay today. *"My purpose is to bring the world to Christ."* True, and unpayable on a Tuesday when you have two exams and a headache. **A placeholder you cannot feed on your worst day is not a placeholder. It is a wish.**

Small and daily beats large and occasional. Every single time.

Before you close this

Two things, and neither takes long.

First, answer the question on page one out loud — *the last year before the mission, or the last year of it.* **Say it, do not just think it.** Everything in these pages rests on that answer being honest, and you are the only person who can give it.

Second, write your sentence. Read the ten. **Either pick the one that is already yours** — the one you read and felt something move — **or write the one you would put in its place**, in your own words, one line.

Then run it against the six tests. If it fails one, do not throw it out. **Fix that one thing and keep the sentence.** A placeholder that needed one repair is still a placeholder; a blank page is not.

Put it where you will see it in the morning. That is the whole assignment, and it is the only one in this document.

---

*The mission gave you two years of proof that you can live like this. It did not give you the multiplier — it **loaned** you one, so that you would know what one feels like and never again mistake a busy life for a multiplied one.*

The mission taught you Divine Math for two years without once calling it by name. Coming home is where you find out whether you learned it — or only borrowed it.

Now you choose your own. That is the whole difference between the two years behind you and the fifty ahead.

Onward, and upward.

— Grampy